

Perseus and Medusa

Danaë was a princess. Her father, Acrisios, was king of Argos, and his worst fear was that she would have a son, because a prophetess had told him that any boy Danaë had would kill him.

To avoid this fate, he locked Danaë in a deep, dank chamber where no one could reach her. No one, that is, except a god. Zeus had fallen in love with Danaë and he sneaked into her prison disguised as a shower of golden rain. Danaë was soon pregnant with his child.

One day, Acrisios heard a loud wailing.

He found that Danaë had given birth to a baby boy, whom she had named Perseus. Acrisios was horrified. He locked his daughter and her child in a heavy wooden chest and threw the chest into the sea, hoping they would drown.

Unfortunately for Acrisios, the chest floated. It bobbed over the sea and came to rest on the island of Seriphos. There, a man named Dictys found it. He unbolted the lid and, to his surprise, found Danaë and Perseus inside. Dictys thought Danaë was very beautiful, and he offered to marry her and raise her son as his own.

One day, years later, Dictys brought Danaë to meet his brother Polydectes, the king of Seriphos.



Dictys was amazed to find Danaë and baby Perseus in the chest.